CHAPTER 10

Totalitarianism: All Power to the Algorithms?

Discussions of the ethics and politics of the new computer network often focus on the fate of democracies. If authoritarian and totalitarian regimes are mentioned, it is mainly as the dystopian destination that 'we' might reach if 'we' fail to manage the computer network wisely.[1] However, as of 2024, more than half of 'us' already live under authoritarian or totalitarian regimes,[2] many of which were established long before the rise of the computer network. To understand the impact of algorithms and AI on humankind, we should ask ourselves what their impact will be not only on democracies like the United States and Brazil but also on the Chinese Communist Party and the royal house of Saud.

As explained in previous chapters, the information technology available in pre-modern eras made both large-scale democracy and large-scale totalitarianism unworkable. Large polities like the Chinese Han Empire and the eighteenth-century Saudi emirate of Diriyah were usually limited autocracies. In the twentieth century, new information technology enabled the rise of both large-scale democracy and large-scale totalitarianism, but totalitarianism suffered from a severe disadvantage. Totalitarianism seeks to channel all information to one hub and process it there. Technologies like the telegraph, the telephone, the typewriter and the radio facilitated the centralisation of information, but they couldn't process the information and make decisions by themselves. This remained something that only humans could do.

The more information flowed to the centre, the harder it became to process it. Totalitarian rulers and parties often made costly mistakes, and